Privacy Audit Report

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AI disclaimer: The structure and formatting of this report were done with the help of ChatGPT to save time and to make the report more visually appealing. All analysis and thoughts were completed by group 7 and not by AI.

Introduction:

This project analyzes how companies collect, share, and protect their user's data and how their private policies line up with the regulatory bodies like GDPR, CCPA, and VCDPA. The platforms analyzed represent a variety of service types. This project highlights critical gaps in user protections that are agreed upon without ever reading them. A typical privacy policy takes about 20 minutes to read and requires a very high reading level, which shows a disconnect between the user agreements and those who are reading them. We are aiming to analyze these agreements and their regulations to evaluate how they collect data.

Overview of Services

Social Media

1. Instagram- Social networking service owned by Meta
2. TikTok- a video hosting service owned by ByteDance
3. X- a microblogging service
4. Facebook- the largest social media platform owned by Meta

Entertainment

1. Steam
2. Epic Games
3. Nintendo

Ride-Sharing

1. Lyft
2. Uber
3. Rapido

Key Findings from Comparison

Agreement Complexity and Readability

All services analyzed employ privacy agreements that call for a college-level reading comprehension, with times ranging from 14 minutes (Instagram) to 33 minutes (X). This high reading level stops many users from attempting to read what they are agreeing to, specifically for companies like TikTok or Instagram, which are geared towards younger users.

Data Collection

The social media platforms collect extensive behavior, biometric, location, and interaction data, raising red flags for those with the ability to comprehend their agreements. The Meta companies collect the broadest range of data, including cross-platform activity across all Meta products. TikTok is not far behind, extensively collecting biometric and voice data.

Data Sharing

All the services analyzed share data with third parties to differing levels. Social media platforms share data much more broadly with advertisers, analytics firms, and partners. Meta services share data across their platforms to create a comprehensive user profile.

Detailed Service Analysis

Ride-Sharing App Privacy Policy Comparison

A comparative overview of privacy practices across major ride-sharing platforms

Company	Agreement Length	Estimated Reading Time	Data Collected	Data Shared With	User Rights	Opt-Out Options	Notable Observations
Lyft	~7,000 words	~30 mins	Location, trip history, payment details, device info, app usage frequency, and ride patterns.	Drivers, payment processors, service providers, and some business partners.	View trip history, update account info, and request data deletion.	Limit location access (only while using app); opt out of marketing emails.	Location tracking is required for the service, so full privacy control is limited.
Uber	~8,500 words	~35 mins	Real-time location, trip details, contact info, payment data, device info, and background usage patterns.	Drivers, affiliates, payment providers, and law enforcement when required.	Access, download, and delete data; control some privacy settings.	Turn off certain tracking features; limit marketing communications.	Similar to Lyft but slightly more detailed in data collection and sharing practices.

Rapido	~6,000 words	~25 mins	Location, trip details, phone number, and payment info. Focuses on ride tracking and user identification.	Drivers, service providers, and partners for operations and payments.	Access account info and request changes or deletion.	Limited options; mainly for promotional messages.	Simpler compared to Uber/Lyft but still relies heavily on location data.
Ola	~7,500 words	~30 mins	Location data, ride history, payment details, device information, app usage, and preferences.	Drivers, affiliates, and third-party vendors for service and analytics.	Access, update, and delete personal data.	Opt out of marketing; control some data permissions in settings.	Similar to Uber in structure; policies may vary by region.
Door Dash	~6,500 words	~25 mins	Location, order history, payment details, device info, and app usage data	Delivery partners, payment processors, service providers, and business partners	Access, update account info, request data deletion, and download data	Opt out of marketing emails; limit location tracking in settings	Collects detailed order and location data; privacy controls are available but somewhat limited
Insta cart	~7,000 words	~28 mins	Personal info, location data, shopping history, payment details, device information, and usage data	Retail partners, delivery shoppers, payment processors, service providers, and analytics partners	Access, update, and delete personal data; request data copies; manage preferences	Opt out of marketing emails; limit tracking through app/device settings	Focuses heavily on purchase and location data; provides moderate privacy controls but relies on third-party partners

Common Features Across Companies

Across all the companies, there are many similar patterns in how they handle user data. Most of them collect basic information like name, contact details, payment information, and device data. They also collect location data and track how users interact with the app, especially in services like ride-sharing and food delivery.

Another common point is that all companies share data with third parties such as service providers, delivery partners, and payment processors. This is mainly done to provide and improve their services.

In addition, all companies give users some basic rights, like accessing their data, updating it, or requesting deletion. They also allow users to opt out of marketing emails, but full control over data collection is still limited. Overall, their privacy policies are quite similar in terms of data collection, sharing, and user control.

Key Differences Between Companies

Even though all the companies follow a similar approach to collecting and using user data, there are clear differences in how they handle privacy. Companies like Uber and Uber Eats collect more detailed information, including user behavior and usage patterns, and they also provide better privacy controls compared to others. Lyft offers similar services but slightly less detailed control and transparency than Uber.

On the other hand, DoorDash and Instacart also collect important data like location, order history, and payment details, but their privacy controls are more limited, especially when it comes to restricting tracking and managing data sharing.

Companies like Ola and Rapido show the most difference, as their privacy policies are less detailed and provide fewer options for users to control their data. Another key difference is in data sharing practices. While all companies share data with third parties, some focus mainly on service-related sharing, while others also use data for advertising and analytics.

Overall, the main differences between these companies are in how much data they collect, how clearly they explain their policies, and how much control they give users over their personal information

Privacy Comparison

When comparing all the companies, there are some noticeable differences in how they handle user privacy. Among them, Uber Eats and Uber provide slightly better privacy protection because they offer more detailed explanations about data collection and give users more control options, such as accessing, downloading, and deleting their data. They are also more transparent in explaining how user information is used.

Lyft also provides similar user rights, but its level of detail and control is slightly less compared to Uber. On the other hand, companies like DoorDash and Instacart provide basic privacy features, but their controls are more limited, especially when it comes to restricting data tracking and sharing.

Ola and Rapido offer the least transparency among all, as their privacy policies are less detailed and provide fewer user control options. Overall, while all companies collect and share user data, Uber and Uber Eats stand out slightly due to better transparency and stronger user control, making them comparatively better in terms of privacy protection.

Notable Observations

One important observation from the analysis is that all companies heavily rely on collecting location data, which is essential for their services, especially in ride-sharing and food delivery platforms. This shows that certain types of data collection are unavoidable for these business models.

Another key observation is that even though all companies provide user rights such as access, update, and deletion of data, the level of control is still limited. In most cases, users can manage

basic settings, but they cannot fully stop data collection or completely control how their data is shared with third parties.

It is also noticeable that companies like Uber and Uber Eats are more transparent and provide clearer explanations about how user data is used, while others like Ola and Rapido are less detailed, which can make it harder for users to fully understand their privacy policies.

Additionally, data sharing with third parties is very common across all companies, especially with service providers, partners, and analytics tools. This increases concerns about how widely user data is distributed beyond the main platform.

Overall, the analysis highlights that while privacy policies exist to inform users, they are often complex and not very user-friendly. Most users may not fully understand them, which raises concerns about awareness and informed consent in digital services.

Social Media

Comparison Matrix

Company	Length	Time	Collection	Sharing	Rights	Opt-Out	GDPR	CCPA	Key
Instagram	3512	14 mins	Account info, behavioral data, location data, content, interactions	Meta apps, advertisers, analytics firms, law enforcement	Access, deletion	Targeted ads, account deletion	Partial	Partial	Cross-platform data used for monetization
TikTok	7051	28 mins	Personal info, content, behavioral data, biometric data, location data	ByteDance group, advertisers, law enforcement	Deletion of data and account	Opt-out for CA minors	Minimal	Minimal	Content licensing
X	8383	33 mins	Text, photos, videos, location data, interactions	Ad partners, analytics, law enforcement, AI developers	Account deletion	Limited controls	Minimal	Minimal	AI model training, no content liability
Facebook	6500	26 mins	Profile data, connections, interactions, off-platform activity	Meta ecosystem, ad partners, vendors, researchers	Access, download, deletion	Targeted ads, facial recognition	Moderate	Moderate	User profiles, AI training

Social Media Platforms

1. Instagram – This policy comes in at 3,512 words, approximately 15 minutes to read at a college level. They collect extensive user data, including account information, behavioral data, and advertising interactions. This data is shared across all Meta products. Third-party partners, advertisers, analytics firms, and law enforcement, as needed. They protect your accounts behind encryption, access controls, and two-factor identification for login purposes. Instagram is partially compliant with CCPA and has not addressed VCDPA or CPA requirements.

2. TikTok – TikTok's policy is 7,051 words, which takes a college-reading-level person 30 minutes to read. They collect personal identifiers, user content, behavioral data, device information, location data, and biometric/ and voice data, which they share with the

ByteDance corporate group, third-party service providers, advertisers, and law enforcement. TikTok offers data and account deletion options, but with limited user controls, providing no general opt-out from data collection (exceptions being California minors). TikTok has dedicated security teams that provide encryption, anonymization of information, internal access controls, and audits for their systems. They do not follow state privacy regulations beyond basic CCPA provisions.

3. X – Taking 33 minutes to read at 8,383 words, X's policy is full of complex legal terminology. It outlines the collection of text, photos, videos, location data, technical data, interaction data, and how it uses content for machine learning training. X shares its data with advertising partners, analytics services, law enforcement, and AI model developers, and provides account deletion options without granular data controls for the user.

4. Facebook – This user agreement is 6,500 words and is estimated to take 25 minutes to read. Facebook collects profile information, connections, content interactions, device information, purchase activity, third-party integrated data, facial recognition, and off-platform activities and shares this data with all the Meta applications, advertising partners, measurement partners, vendors, service providers, researchers, and law enforcement. Facebook offers all the same security measures as the first three companies, in addition to more enhanced suspicious activity detection. Facebook complies with GDPR and CCPA requirements, but has not addressed newer state regulations.

Regulatory Compliance Assessment

GDPR: All services explored during this analysis claim to follow compliance, but there is no way to know the extent of it. Meta apps meet the basic requirements but seem to have very complex agreements with very little transparency, while other apps like Titok or X barely comply due to the language used in their policies. Overall, there seems to be a vague, complex language.

Conclusion

Our analysis shows that digital privacy regulations have failed to significantly alter the issues driving ethical data use. While they improve practices, there is a very significant gap between the legal aspect and actual user understanding. This distance is explained by understanding the business models and decisions that shape private policies. Advertising Revenue is the one leading the market since it is protected by ambiguous and complex language. Hopefully, Privacy Policies will be seen as tools of education for users and not just another checkbox to mark.